

SERVANTS AND suburbia

SOCIAL CLASS IN THE WEST

By the mid-19th century, the middle class (or *bourgeoisie*) was expanding rapidly as a result of the increasing trade and wealth created by the Industrial Revolution, and was becoming more and more separated from the working class. The expanding middle class was most evident in Britain, northwestern Europe, and the US. The bourgeoisie ranged from the *haute* (upper) including factory owners and bankers, to the *petite* (petty)—clerks, teachers, and shopkeepers. What distinguished them all from the working class was that they did not work with their hands. The middle class viewed themselves as the respectable, thrifty, and sober bedrock of society, and distanced themselves from what they saw as the feckless working class and indolent aristocracy.

The housewife

Due to rising real wages most middle-class families—and some working-class ones—could live on one salary: the husband's. This led to the “male breadwinner” model and the notion that a woman's place was in the home. A wife's duty was to be meek, obedient, and run the household. Managing domestic servants

was a key skill and being able to afford at least one maid was an important mark of the bourgeois household. Numerous books were published to guide wives with advice on cooking, entertaining, and childcare. These ideas about a wife's role were to persist for some time—in Ireland, with the exception of teachers, wives could not work until 1973.

The working class mostly lived in urban areas, worked in factories and mines, and their only possession of any significant value was their labor. The middle classes, on the other hand, as a result of the introduction of mass-transit commuter systems, were able to move

▼ Life below stairs

These two women posing with household utensils are Victorian servants from around 1880. By 1891, 1.3 million girls and women worked as domestic servants in Victorian England.



► Picture perfect

This photograph of an American middle-class family at home in 1910 shows the women sewing and reading surrounded by material possessions—indicating the affluence of the head of the house.



“NEATNESS SHOULD
BE STUDIED BY
ALL ENGAGED IN
DOMESTIC WORK.”

ISABELLA BEETON, *BOOK OF HOUSEHOLD MANAGEMENT*, 1861